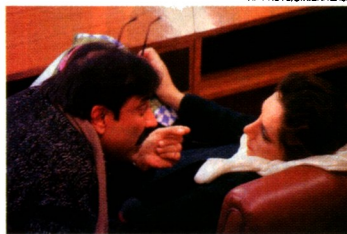
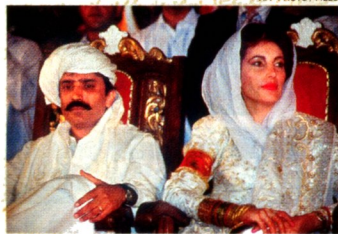


# ROLLERCOASTER RIDE

There are polarised opinions about Asif Zardari, the man who may soon be Pakistan's political kingmaker. An intimate portrait.



**PARTNERS IN LIFE:** (Left) Zardari and Bhutto on the day of their marriage in 1987; the couple in parliament while they were in the Opposition



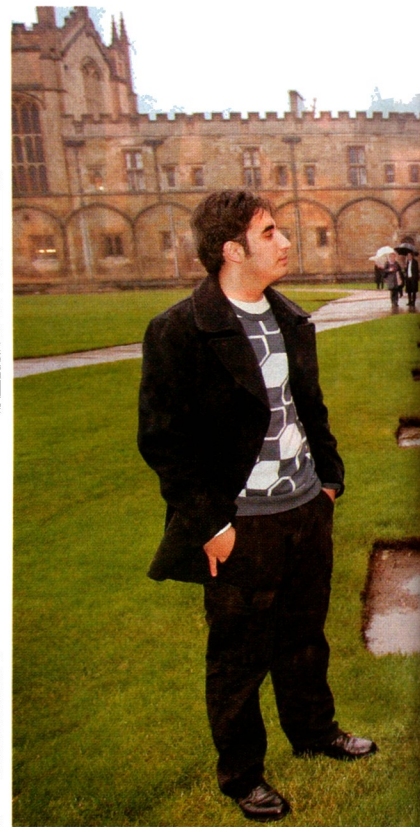
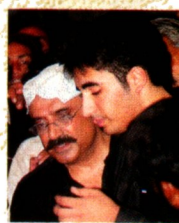
**STATE MATTERS:** (Left) In the White House in 1989 with the then US president Bush and first lady Barbara Bush; (below left) introducing their children to the then Palestine president Yasser Arafat in Islamabad in 1996



**TURBULENT TIMES:** (Right) Zardari after being charged with a murder conspiracy in 1997; (above) celebrating his return to Lahore in 2005



**BLACK DAYS:** (Right) Zardari comforts son Bilawal after Bhutto's assassination; (left) mourners at the mausoleum in Larkana



eight years in self-imposed exile in Dubai and London. While she campaigned fearlessly, he kept a low profile, shuttling between New York and Dubai to keep an eye on their three children, Bilawal, Bakhtawar and Asifa. Party seniors had indicated that it would be wise to keep the controversial Zardari out of the election fray as he was perceived as Bhutto's liability. Labelled "Mr 10 Per Cent" by his opponents during her first term in government—a reference to the alleged kickbacks earned on government contracts—Zardari spent almost 11 years in jail on a variety of charges (see box) that have yet to be proved in court. He survived a heart attack and a debilitating spinal ailment that rendered him invalid for a while.

Yet, hours after the assassination, Zardari proved himself to be the man for the crisis. He is now lauded for showing political sagacity in deciding to take a back seat to his 19-year-old son Bilawal, whom he named the new chairperson of the Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP). Simultaneously he nomi-